

CPA Interview Sheet

KeyVex

Use this on at least three candidates so you can compare. About 30 minutes per call. Note the *vibe* as well as the answers — does the person return calls, talk to you like a peer, get defensive about fees? Sit on it for 24 hours before choosing.

Fit & experience

- Tell me about your typical client.

Good answer: small businesses, LLCs, startups, service/tech mix. Red flag: big corporates only, or a vague “we do everything.”

- How many small LLCs or S-corps do you handle?
- Familiar with our state’s rules — and any county-specific filings?
- Any experience with software / SaaS businesses?

Scope of services

- Do you do bookkeeping, tax prep, or both?
- Which filings are included? Federal income tax. State. County / local. Quarterly estimated taxes. Sales tax (if applicable). 1099s.
- Will you advise on entity tax election — whether and when an LLC should elect S-corp status?
- Available year-round, or just at tax time?
- Do you provide audit support if it ever comes up?
- Familiar with Section 174 (R&D / software development cost amortization)?

Working style & software

- What accounting software do you require or prefer?

Good answer: QuickBooks Online, Wave, or Xero. Red flag: proprietary in-house software, or “email me PDFs.”

- How do we share sensitive documents — secure portal?

Red flag: email attachments of tax docs.

- Typical turnaround on a quick question by email?
- Two principals — Derek and Greg are co-owners. Comfortable working with both?

Fees

- Flat annual, hourly, or monthly retainer?
- What’s included in the base fee, and what’s extra?
- Ballpark for a 2-person LLC at our stage — what does year one look like?

- Setup fees?

Red flag: won't quote a range, "we'll figure it out as we go."

Onboarding

- What does the first 90 days look like?
- What records do you need up front?
- Will you set up our chart of accounts in the bookkeeping software?

Universal red flags

- Vague on fees.
- Pushes software you've never heard of.
- Hard to reach during the call already.
- "Tax season only" — disappears the rest of the year.
- Promises that sound too good ("we'll cut your tax bill in half").
- Asks for SSN / EIN over unsecured email.

Candidate scorecard

Fill in by hand on the call. Rows are the fields to capture; columns are the three candidates you interview.

Field	Candidate A	Candidate B	Candidate C
Firm / CPA name			
Date interviewed			
Estimated annual cost			
Fit (1–5)			
Software they use			
Familiar with our state?			
Response-time feel			
Notes			

Decision criteria

The right CPA is **responsive**, **transparent about fees**, **comfortable in modern software**, and a firm where **your size is normal**. Don't pick the most impressive credentials — pick the one you'll actually *call* when you have a question.